

Smartphones more powerful than netbooks

It's bound to happen. The writing's on the wall...

Ever since Apple launched the iPhone back in 2007, the race was on among competing manufacturers leaving no stone unturned, to clone it. It's absolutely nuts how the mobile phone industry has just exploded over the past 5 years, especially the advent of smartphones. As a result, consumers have never been in a better position to buy just the right smartphone they desire. As smartphone sales continue to rise and enjoy a sizable chunk of the market, the pace of innovation is blazingly fast as different brands try to woo customers, and mobile phones are slowly morphing into devices we could scarcely imagine some time back.

It's all in the cores

Last year saw the first iPhone ever to sport a dual-core processor, the iPhone 4S, and companies like Samsung, LG, and HTC debut the very first dual-core smartphones of their respective fleets — viz. Samsung Galaxy SII, LG Optimus 2X, and HTC Sensation, respectively. During the course of this year, we expect dual-core smartphones to be priced competitively and available at affordable rates. While it's great to have dual-core phones all around, but what about the apps to utilize all that processing power? By all indications, apps that exploit multiple cores and multiple threads will become more mainstream this year. Does that also mean gigantic batteries for 4-inch and larger-screen-sized smartphones? No, definitely not. ARM's Cortex A15 chip due later this year will roughly be twice as powerful (with a max core clock speed of 2.5 GHz)

DEATH OF MUSIC CD

With the rise of online music stores like iTunes and related music services, major music labels are mulling over retiring compact discs for selling albums.

Although they declined to comment, Sony, EMI, and Universal are seriously contemplating cutting down or stop producing music CDs in general—whatever stocks they do produce will be limited edition for select artists sold through Amazon alone. This may happen later this year.

as the existing Cortex A9 chip, with no word on battery usage. But the lower-end Cortex A7, a successor to the Cortex A8 chip abundant in smartphones right now, will definitely be twice as fast with up to 5x more power efficient than any Cortex A8 chip-based smartphone of today.

Of course, the first quad-core (yes, you read that right, 4 cores!) smartphone is also slated for release later this year, it's the HTC Edge, the first of its kind in the world. It will have four cores clocked at 1.5 GHz each, that's quicker than any commercially available netbook available in the market currently. This is possible because the HTC Edge will be based on NVIDIA's Tegra 3 chipset, the next big step in smartphone hardware in 2012. The HTC Edge and others in its mould which are expected to crop up sooner rather than later, will also offer better-than-ever graphics for upcoming smartphones and devices sporting a handheld form factor.

Industry giants want a piece of the action

What's more interesting is that brands and manufacturers who aren't traditionally associated with the mobile phone industry are also trying to make a dent in the market. Take Intel for example, a chip maker that's only ever traditionally associated with the PCs, it will now vie for a major stake in the smartphone market starting this year. If you're wondering how, the answer is simple: Intel will release two distinct chips later in the year -- 32nm Medfield (Atom variant) for smartphones and Clover Trail for tablets. With Medfield, Intel hopes to make a significant dent into the ARM-dominant smartphone market, while Clover Trail aims to take on NVID-



“ GPUs are no longer considered niche, and over the last year, our mobile phones have emerged as our “personal” computers in the truest sense of the term. ”

— Vishal Dhupar, MD, NVIDIA (South Asia)

IA's Tegra 3 and Apple's new tablet chipset expected later this year.

Even Amazon, who released their first 7-inch Android tablet last year, is reportedly working with Foxconn to unveil its very first smartphone. Specs are rumoured that the yet-unnamed Amazon phone will have a 4-inch display and an 8MP camera. This is definitely a sign that Amazon is expanding its business to upset the balance of power in the mobile industry. If that wasn't surprising enough, listen to this: Facebook is also working on a secret phone project. Yes, you read it right, the social networking giant is working closely with HTC to release a Facebook-branded handset early this year. Codenamed Buffy, the Facebook phone will run on a homebrew version of Android and support developer apps running on HTML5.

Soon every Tom, Dick and Harry will tout a smartphone, leading us to believe the devices will soon leave existing netbooks behind in the performance race. **d**